

Ascaphus truei

Tailed frog

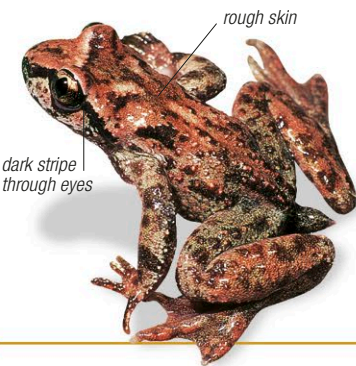


Length 1–2 in (2.5–5 cm)
Habit Mostly terrestrial
Breeding Spring to season fall
Status Least concern

Location S.W. Canada, N.W. USA



This small green, brown, gray, or reddish amphibian is the only aquatic frog that breeds by internal fertilization. The unique “tail”—found only in males—is an extension of the cloaca, and is used to insert sperm into the female’s cloaca. Females lay strings of eggs in cold mountain streams, attaching them to the underside of rocks. The tadpoles take 2 years to mature, and have suckerlike mouths that enable them to cling to rocks in fast-flowing water.



Xenopus laevis

African clawed toad



Length 2¼–5 in (6–13 cm)
Habit Mostly aquatic
Breeding Rainy season season
Status Least concern

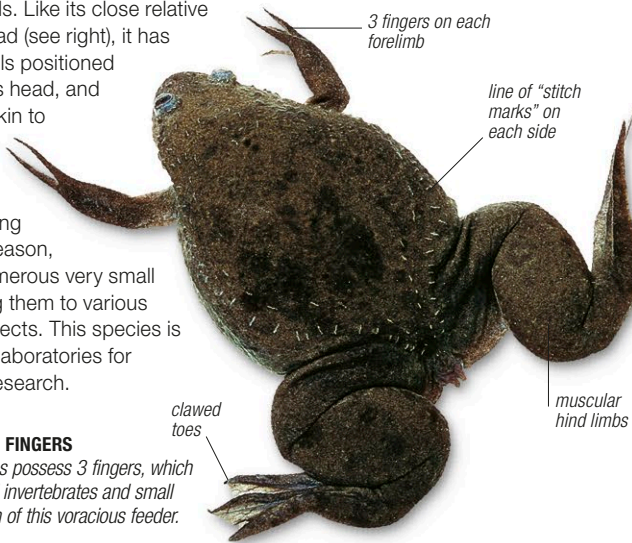
Location C. and Southern Africa. Introduced to USA and Europe



With its flattened body and large, webbed feet, the African clawed toad (also known as the platanna) is ideally suited to a bottom-dwelling lifestyle in lakes and ponds. Like its close relative the Surinam toad (see right), it has eyes and nostrils positioned on the top of its head, and camouflaged skin to protect it from herons and other predators. During the breeding season, females lay numerous very small eggs, attaching them to various underwater objects. This species is often raised in laboratories for teaching and research.

FORELIMBS WITH FINGERS

The small forelimbs possess 3 fingers, which are used to shovel invertebrates and small fish into the mouth of this voracious feeder.



Leiopelma hochstetteri

Hochstetter’s frog



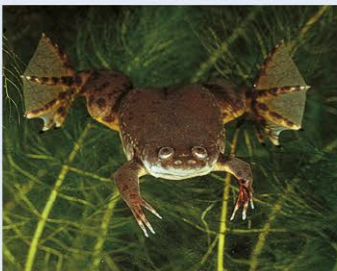
Length 1½–2 in (3.5–5 cm)
Habit Mostly terrestrial
Breeding Summer season
Status Least concern

Location New Zealand (North Island)



This squat brown frog—an inhabitant of damp ground—is one of just 4 species of frogs that are native to New Zealand. Its eggs, which are enclosed in large, water-filled capsules, develop into nonfeeding tadpoles that stay within the capsule until they mature. When they are fully developed, they emerge as froglets. Hochstetter’s frog is still abundant in some localized areas, but 2 other New Zealand species are now very rare, and confined to offshore islands.

SENSE ORGANS



This toad has a line of white “stitch marks” along its sides. These contain special sense organs that detect vibrations, helping it to locate food and predators in murky water.

Bombina orientalis

Oriental fire-bellied toad



Length 1¼–2 in (3–5 cm)
Habit Mostly aquatic
Breeding Spring and season summer
Status Least concern

Location E. and S.E. Asia



The most distinctive feature of this squat, slightly flattened toad is its bright red underside with black mottling. When threatened, it arches its back, flattens its body,

and lifts its limbs over its head to display this vivid coloration. It also produces a distasteful secretion through its skin. The Oriental fire-bellied toad lives in mountain streams in coastal areas, and hides under rocks and logs in winter and during dry spells. The male calls to attract a mate. The female lays small clutches of large eggs under rocks in streams.



Pipa pipa

Surinam toad



Length 2–8 in (5–20 cm)
Habit Wholly aquatic
Breeding Rainy season season
Status Least concern

Location N. South America



The Surinam toad is gray above and paler below, with a flattened body and flat, triangular head. Like other members of the family Pipidae, it lacks a tongue. An inhabitant of turbid, muddy,

and slow-moving water, the Surinam toad is highly adapted to an entirely aquatic existence. Powerful hind limbs aid swimming, sense organs along its sides detect vibrations in the muddy water, tentacle-like projections on its fingers feel for prey, and upward-pointing eyes see above the surface. This toad exhibits unusual mating and breeding patterns: the male clasps the female from above, and the pair turns upside down repeatedly. The eggs are released, fertilized, and trapped in the space between the male’s belly and the female’s back. They are then absorbed into the skin on the female’s back, where they develop in capsules and emerge as miniature frogs.



Alytes muletensis

Majorcan midwife toad



Length 1½–1¾ in (3.5–4.5 cm)
Habit Mostly terrestrial
Breeding Spring and season summer
Status Vulnerable

Location Balearic Islands (Majorca)



One of the world’s most rare toads, this tiny species (also known as the ferreret) has been the subject of a very successful conservation program, in which animals

bred in captivity are released into suitable habitats on Majorca. It has a yellowish or pale brown body, with dark mottling. Both the males and females call to locate mates. The female transfers a batch of eggs to the male, who carries them until they are ready to hatch. Their tadpoles grow very large, and little growth occurs after they become adults.

